

Title

Primary Care Psychological Intervention for Post-ICU Trauma Symptoms: Protocol for a Randomized Clinical Trial

Abstract

Background: Intensive care unit survivors frequently experience posttraumatic stress symptoms affecting quality of life, yet few interventions are tested in primary care settings. This protocol describes a randomized evaluation of a brief psychologically-informed intervention delivered by general practitioners. **Methods:** We will randomize approximately 310 adult ICU survivors with clinically significant PTSD symptoms to receive either a brief exposure-based intervention delivered by their primary care physician (4-6 sessions over 3 months) or enhanced usual care consisting of regular primary care plus psychoeducational materials. Participants will be identified through ICU discharge records and contacted for screening. Primary outcomes measure health-related quality of life at 6 and 12 months using standardized instruments. Secondary outcomes include PTSD symptom severity, anxiety, depression, and functional outcomes. Mediation analyses will examine whether improvements in PTSD symptoms explain quality-of-life gains. Participants will provide questionnaire data at baseline, 3 months, 6 months, and 12 months. This pragmatic trial will evaluate implementation feasibility and cost-effectiveness of primary-care-based mental health intervention.